PHILOSOPHY PAPER II — PHILOSOPHY OF RELIGION 01 — NOTIONS OF GOD

ONE CONTINUOUS REVISION RAIL • MEANING → WESTERN MODELS → ATTRIBUTES → CONFLICTS → INDIAN SCHOOLS → GOD-WORLD-HUMAN RELATIONS → CRITICISM → 13 VERIFIED PYQ ROUTES

Read the cyan rail from Stage 0 to Stage 14. Every stage carries the exact distinctions needed to reconstruct a Philosophy Optional answer at a glance. The complete Basic / Must-Know spine ends before the lighter optional enrichment stage.

● BASIC / MUST KNOW ● ATTRIBUTE-CONFLICT PIVOT ● OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT

AMBER = doctrine • CYAN = mechanism • RED = trap/objection • TEAL = Indian parity • MAGENTA = answer-grabbing formulation

Approval: FALSE • Generated 2026-08-22 • Pending explicit user review

STAGE 0 IDENTITY + READING RULE — A GOD-CONCEPT IS A METAPHYSICAL PROFILE

NATURE · ATTRIBUTES · WORLD RELATION · HUMAN RELATION · RELIGIOUS FUNCTION · PROOF IS TOPIC 02

FIVE CONTROL QUESTIONS

- **What is ultimate?** Person, substance, consciousness, qualified whole or intelligent governor?
- **Which predicates apply?** Power, knowledge, goodness, eternity, simplicity?
- **How is the world related?** Creation, identity, appearance, body or arrangement?
- **How is the person related?** Creature, mode, identity, inseparable part or dependent self?
- **What practice follows?** Prayer, knowledge, devotion, surrender, recognition or rational freedom?

TOPIC FIREWALL

- A first cause is **not yet** personal, omniscient, good or worship-worthy.
- Proofs for existence are bounded cross-links; this topic owns the **content and coherence** of the alleged divine terminus.
- Problem of evil is linked because its force changes with the God-concept, but it remains a separate syllabus owner.

COMPLETE-ANSWER RULE

- Hold the axis constant when comparing schools.
- Do not contrast one system's ontology with another's devotional practice without supplying the missing metaphysical link.
- Every evaluation uses **objection → best reply → residual pressure**.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A notion of God is a package of claims about ultimacy, attributes and relations; its adequacy must be argued as a package, not assumed from a sacred name.

STAGE 1 CONCEPTUAL GRAMMAR — PERSONALITY, LOCATION AND LANGUAGE ARE DIFFERENT AXES

PERSONAL ≠ PHYSICAL · IMPERSONAL ≠ INERT · TRANSCENDENT ≠ FAR AWAY · IMMANENT ≠ IDENTICAL · CATAPHATIC · APOPHATIC

THREE INDEPENDENT QUESTIONS

AXIS	EXACT MEANING	EXAM-SAFE EXAMPLES / LIMIT
Personal / impersonal	Intellect, will and relation versus transpersonal ultimacy.	Classical theism and Rāmānuja are personal; Spinoza and nirguṇa Brahman are impersonal in different senses.
Transcendent / immanent	Ontological independence versus sustaining or indwelling presence.	Theism may affirm both. Immanence alone does not entail pantheistic identity.
Cataphatic / apophatic	Positive predication versus denial of creaturely limitation.	Good/wise/loving may be affirmed analogically; *neti neti* prevents objectification.

CATAPHATIC RISK

Positive God-talk

- Univocal transfer of human psychology can make God a magnified finite person.
- Reply: predicate perfection analogically, denying creaturely limitation.

BALANCE

Affirm without anthropomorphism; negate without emptiness.

APOPHATIC RISK

Negative theology

- If every positive predicate disappears, reference and worship become indeterminate.
- Reply: negation removes limits while directional content remains.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Personal/impersonal describes the grammar of agency; transcendent/immanent describes relation to the world; cataphatic/apophatic controls how predicates are used.

STAGE 2 WESTERN MODEL FAMILY — DISTINCTION, WITHDRAWAL, IDENTITY OR INCLUSION

THEISM: GOD ≠ WORLD · DEISM: CREATES → WITHDRAWS · PANTHEISM: GOD = NATURE · PANENTHEISM: WORLD IN GOD · PROVIDENCE · RELIGIOUS REMOTENESS

CLASSICAL THEISM
Personal necessary creator; distinct from yet continuously sustaining creation.

→ **DEISM**
Creator and lawgiver; no continuing miracle, revelation or special providence.

→ **PANTHEISM**
No external creator-world gap; Spinoza's one infinite substance.

→ **PANENTHEISM**
World exists in God, but God is not exhausted by the world.

CLOSE-OPTION DISTINCTIONS

TEST	THEISM	DEISM	PANTHEISM	PANENTHEISM
World formula	Distinct + sustained	Distinct + autonomous	Identity / modal dependence	Inclusion + divine excess
Divine action	Providence and sustaining cause	No special intervention	Necessary self-expression	Internal relation varies by model
Main pressure	Evil and coherence	Remote God	Loss of personality/freedom	Meaning of 'in God'

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Pantheism uses identity, panentheism inclusion-with-excess, theism dependence-with-distinction and deism creation-with-withdrawal.

STAGE 3 CREATOR AND DEPENDENCE — CREATION EX NIHILO IS NOT MANUFACTURE

EX NIHILO · NOTHING IS NOT MATERIAL · TOTAL ONTOLOGICAL DEPENDENCE · SUSTAINING CAUSATION · PRIMARY / SECONDARY CAUSES · NO PHYSICAL BODY REQUIRED

ORDINARY MAKER

- Uses pre-existing material, tools, bodily motion and temporal sequence.
- Exists inside the same physical order as the product.
- Analogy may suggest intelligence but cannot dictate the ontology of an ultimate cause.

FROM MANUFACTURE TO DEPENDENCE →

CLASSICAL CREATOR

- Gives and sustains the whole being of creatures; no independent primordial matter is presupposed.
- Acts as primary cause through genuine secondary natural causes.
- Creation concerns dependence, not a first rearrangement of material.

CONTINUITY CAUTION Creation ex nihilo does not mean that 'nothing' is a substance from which God makes the world. It denies an independent material co-principle.

2024 ROUTE → Physical manifestation may disclose a cause epistemically, but it is not logically required for non-physical, sustaining, efficient or metaphysical causation. Rāmānuja's world-as-body is not a finite divine anatomy.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Ultimacy requires non-dependence; making a finite physical form necessary would make the alleged ultimate cause dependent upon matter, location and change.

STAGE 4 CLASSICAL ATTRIBUTE PACKAGE — MAXIMAL PERFECTIONS PLUS NON-DEPENDENCE

OMNIPOTENCE · OMNISCIENCE · PERFECT GOODNESS · ETERNITY / TIMELESSNESS · IMMUTABILITY / IMPASSIBILITY · NECESSITY / ASEITY / SIMPLICITY

ATTRIBUTE LEDGER

ATTRIBUTE	CORE MEANING	DO NOT CONFUSE WITH
Omnipotence	Power over every absolutely/logically possible state consistent with perfect nature.	Making contradictions true or exercising total control at every moment.
Omniscience	Knowledge of every truth; classical accounts include future and counterfactual truths.	Causal determination of the known act.
Perfect goodness	No willing evil as evil; moral perfection is intrinsic.	External obedience to a higher moral law.
Eternity	Timeless possession of life or everlasting duration.	Merely surviving for a very long time.
Immutability / impassibility	No change in essential perfection; not involuntarily overpowered by passion.	Inertness, indifference or absence of active love.
Necessity / aseity	Cannot fail to exist; derives existence from nothing else.	Self-causation.
Simplicity	No metaphysical composition; attributes are one reality diversely conceived.	Being easy to understand or lacking rich predicates.

PACKAGE RULE → These attributes are connected. A change in timelessness, simplicity or goodness changes what power, knowledge, freedom and personality mean.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The classical God is not a finite super-agent with more properties; the claim is an underived, non-composite reality whose perfections are mutually coherent.

STAGE 5 ATTRIBUTE-CONFLICT PIVOT — EVERY STANDARD REPLY HAS A COST

STONE PARADOX · FOREKNOWLEDGE / FREEDOM · GOODNESS / EVIL · IMMUTABILITY / LOVE · TIMELESSNESS / ACTION · SIMPLICITY / MANY PREDICATES

CONFLICT → REPLY → RESIDUAL PRESSURE

CONFLICT	PRESSURE	STANDARD REPLY	WHAT REMAINS
Power / logic	Can God make a stone God cannot lift?	Contradictions do not specify possible tasks.	Does the qualification become ad hoc?
Foreknowledge / freedom	Infallible knowledge appears to close alternatives.	Knowledge is not causation; timeless present or soft past fact.	Modal fixity may remain.
Goodness / evil	Knows, can prevent, is good — yet evil.	Free-will defence, soul-making, permitted risk.	Natural and apparently gratuitous evil.
Immutability / love	Real response seems to involve change.	Unchanging nature with changing creaturely relations.	Reciprocity remains difficult.
Timelessness / action	How can a timeless cause act at a time?	One timeless act has temporal effects.	Agency without succession is obscure.
Simplicity / predicates	How can one reality be wise, good and powerful?	Conceptual plurality, ontological identity.	Modal collapse and property-identity objections.

FREEDOM OPTIONS

- Compatibilist reason-responsiveness.
- Libertarian ability to do otherwise.
- Boethian eternity, Ockhamism, Molinism or open theism each pays a different cost.

SPECIFY TERMS

The answer is won by naming the premise denied.

INDIAN PARITY

- Nyāya: karmic administration preserves *puruṣakāra*.
- Rāmānuja: divine permission sustains capacity; jīva owns the moral act.
- Advaita relocates freedom to release from ignorance.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The attribute package survives only after each perfection is specified; a reply that saves coherence may still reduce religious intelligibility or explanatory power.

STAGE 6 SPINOZA — ONE SUBSTANCE, INFINITE ATTRIBUTES, FINITE MODES

DEUS SIVE NATURA · CAUSA SUI · THOUGHT + EXTENSION · MODES DEPEND · NATURA NATURANS / NATURATA · FREEDOM THROUGH NECESSITY

SUBSTANCE
Exists in itself and is conceived through itself; absolutely infinite substance excludes every rival.

↓ **ATTRIBUTES**
What intellect perceives as constituting substance's essence; humans know Thought and Extension.

↓ **MODES**
Finite dependent expressions under attributes; a mind or body is not the whole God.

↓ **NECESSARY ORDER**
Natura naturans is active self-caused nature; natura naturata is the modal order that follows.

↓ **HUMAN FREEDOM**
Not uncaused choice: greater action from adequate understanding rather than passive determination.

WHAT SPINOZA GAINS

- Radical immanence, unity and explanatory necessity.
- No external constraint upon God; divine freedom is self-determination.
- Mind/body parallel expression avoids two created substances.

WHAT SPINOZA LOSES

- No deliberative creator, miracle, providential choice or petitionary relation.
- Libertarian freedom and ordinary desert are heavily revised.
- Pantheism must not be reduced to 'everything is individually the whole God'.

PYQ ROUTES

- **2022, 10m:** notion of God and attributes.
- **2024, 15m:** embedding in substance and attribute metaphysics; critical discussion.
- Always define substance → attribute → mode before evaluating.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Spinoza does not place God beside the world: the world is the necessary modal expression of the one infinite substance, and freedom becomes rational self-determination within necessity.

STAGE 7 ADVAITA — NIRGUṆA BRAHMAN, SAGUṆA ĪŚVARA AND DEPENDENT APPEARANCE

SAT-CIT-ĀNANDA · NETI NETI · MĀYĀ / ADHYĀSA · VIVARTA · THREE LEVELS · ANIRVACANĪYA = MĀYĀ, NOT BRAHMAN

NIRGUṆA — ABSOLUTE

- Non-dual reality beyond limiting relational predicates; not non-being.
- *Sat-cit-ānanda* states essential nature, not three detachable accidents.
- *Neti neti* negates objectification and finite delimitation.
- Ātman is Brahman at the *pāramārthika* level.

ONE BRAHMAN

Two standpoints, not two rival gods.

SAGUṆA ĪŚVARA — EMPIRICAL

- Brahman viewed in relation to māyā: omniscient creator, governor and object of devotion.
- Fully valid within the shared *vyāvahārika* order.
- Theism is religiously real as path, but creator-creature duality is ultimately sublated.

ERROR — Adhyāsa: self and not-self characteristics are superimposed.

APPEARANCE — Māyā makes names, forms and causation available without a second absolute.

WORLD — Vivarta: apparent manifestation without real transformation of Brahman.

LEVELS — Prātibhāsika → vyāvahārika → pāramārthika.

KNOWLEDGE — Sublation reveals identity rather than creating liberation.

PRECISION TRAP → *Anirvacanīya* technically describes māyā/world-appearance as neither absolutely real nor absolutely unreal. Brahman's ineffability is the failure of limiting predication, expressed through *avācya* and *neti neti*.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Śaṅkara leaves room for theism at the empirical level, but the room is provisional because liberating knowledge sublates the final distinction between worshipper, worshipped and world.

STAGE 8 RĀMĀNUJA — QUALIFIED UNITY WITH REAL SELVES, REAL WORLD AND PERSONAL GOD

ĪŚVARA-CIT-ACIT · ŚARĪRA-ŚARĪRĪ · APṚTHAK-SIDDHI · MATERIAL + EFFICIENT CAUSE · PARIṆĀMA / REAL MANIFESTATION · BHAKTI + PRAPATTI

QUALIFIED NON-DUAL ARCHITECTURE

TERM	WHAT IT MEANS	ANSWER CONSEQUENCE
Īśvara	Supreme personal Brahman / Nārāyaṇa with infinite auspicious qualities.	Personality, grace, worship and purposive governance are ultimate.
Cit	Real plurality of conscious selves.	Jīvas know, act, bear karma and retain individuality in liberation.
Acit	Real non-conscious matter in subtle and manifest states.	The world is real, not *mithyā* or mere *vivarta*.
Śarīra-śarīrī	World and selves are God's body; God is indwelling controller.	Body means support, control and purposiveness — not finite anatomy.
Apṛthak-siddhi	Distinct yet inseparable existence.	Jiva is neither numerically identical with nor independent of God.
Causation	God is intelligent efficient and material cause through inseparable cit-acit.	Real manifestation without essential moral defect in God.

RELIGIOUS RESULT

- Bhakti: sustained loving contemplation.
- Prapatti: complete surrender to grace.
- Mokṣa: communion and service with retained selfhood.

UNITY + DIFFERENCE

Organic dependence grounds devotion.

EVIL / DEFECT PRESSURE

- If the world is God's body, does suffering qualify God?
- Reply: defect belongs to dependent body, not controller's essential perfection.
- Residual issue: comprehensive control keeps responsibility alive.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Viśiṣṭādvaita preserves unity without illusion and difference without independence: selves and world are real, distinct and wholly dependent qualifications of one personal Brahman.

STAGE 9 NYĀYA — OMNISCIENT SPECIAL SELF, EFFICIENT CAUSE AND KARMIC ADMINISTRATOR

PLURALIST REALISM · NIMITTA-KĀRAṆA · ETERNAL ATOMS = MATERIAL CAUSE · ADṚṢṬA / KARMA · VEDA AUTHORSHIP · REDUNDANCY OBJECTION

ETERNAL REALITIES
Atoms, selves, space and time remain real; God is not the only substance.

→ **ĪŚVARA**
Eternal omniscient and omnipotent special self, never bound by karma.

→ **ORDERED COSMOS**
God initiates and coordinates atomic combinations; atoms supply material.

→ **MORAL ORDER**
Karma supplies desert; God intelligently allocates fruits and later authors the Veda.

SUPPORTING ARGUMENTS

- *Kāryāt*: the composite world as effect.
- *Āyojanāt*: inert atoms require intelligent arrangement.
- *Dhṛtyādeḥ*: sustaining and dissolving order.
- *Śruteḥ / padāt / vākyāt*: scripture and language require an omniscient source.

OBJECTIONS

- World-maker analogy may overextend intra-worldly causation.
- Karma and eternal atoms appear to divide or replace God's explanatory work.
- Evil remains when God designs and sustains the system.

NYĀYA REPLIES

- Unconscious atoms and *adṛṣṭa* cannot coordinate purposive order.
- God administers rather than arbitrarily creates desert.
- Nature-of-God answers prioritize attributes and causal role, not a catalogue of proofs.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nyāya's God orders rather than materially becomes the world: Īśvara is efficient cause, eternal atoms are material cause, and karma supplies the basis of impartial consequence.

STAGE 10 OTHER INDIAN THEISMS — MADHVA, ŚAIVA AND ŚĀKTA PARITY

MADHVA: SVATANTRA / PARATANTRA · PAÑCA-BHEDA · ŚAIVA: PATI-PAŚU-PĀŚA · PAÑCA-KṚTYA · ŚĀKTA: DEVĪ = ŚAKTI · WORLD REAL IN ALL THREE

MADHVA / DVAITA

- Viṣṇu alone is independent; all else is dependent.
- Five real differences: God-soul, God-matter, soul-soul, soul-matter, matter-matter.
- *Bimba-pratibimba*: reflection/dependence, not identity.
- Liberation retains selfhood, hierarchy and service.

DEPENDENCE WITHOUT ADVAITA'S SUBLATION

Use one school fully when the question permits 'any one religion in India'.

ŚAIVA SIDDHĀNTA

- *Pati-paśu-pāśa*: Lord, soul and bonds (*āṇava*, karma, māyā).
- Śiva is efficient cause; māyā is material cause.
- Five acts: creation, maintenance, dissolution, concealment and grace.
- Soul becomes Śiva-like, never the Lord.

KASHMIR ŚAIVISM

- Śiva as *prakāśa* with *vimarśa* / Śakti.
- World is real self-manifestation through sovereign freedom (*svātantrya*), not Advaitic *vivarta*.
- Liberation is recognition (*pratyabhijñā*).

ŚĀKTA

- Devī/Mahādevī is supreme self-sufficient reality.
- Śakti is not an added property but the dynamic divine itself.
- Unlike Advaita māyā or unconscious Sāṃkhya prakṛti, Śakti is conscious and ultimate.

CLOSE-OPTION TRAPS

- Do not merge dualistic Śaiva Siddhānta with non-dual Kashmir Śaivism.
- Do not turn Madhva's reflection into identity.
- Sectarian theology remains philosophical where it states causation, bondage and liberation criteria.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Indian theism is not exhausted by Advaita and Rāmānuja: Madhva preserves eternal difference, Śaiva systems analyse Lord-soul-bond relations, and Śākta makes divine power itself ultimate.

STAGE 11 DIVINE PLURALITY — DO NOT COLLAPSE EIGHT DIFFERENT CLAIMS

POLYTHEISM · HENOTHEISM · KATHENOTHEISM · MONOLATRY · MONOTHEISM vs MONISM · PANTHEISM vs PANENTHEISM

CLASSIFICATION GRID

TERM	EXACT CLAIM	DECISIVE DISTINCTION
Polytheism	Many genuinely divine beings with divided or overlapping jurisdictions.	Plurality of deities.
Henotheism	Many gods acknowledged; one receives supreme devotion.	Contextual or devotional supremacy.
Kathenotheism	Different gods are successively addressed as supreme.	One-god-at-a-time praise.
Monolatry	One god alone is worshipped without denying others exist.	Practice, not necessarily metaphysics.
Monotheism	One supreme personal God.	Unity of deity.
Monism	Reality is ultimately one.	Unity of reality; need not be personal.
Pantheism	God and reality/Nature are identical.	Identity.
Panentheism	World is in God, while God exceeds world.	Inclusion-with-excess.

HINDUISM VERDICT → Hinduism contains polytheistic practice, henotheistic/kathenotheistic praise, monolatrous devotion, sectarian monotheism, Upaniṣadic monism and qualified theism. The label must state the tradition and level.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Plurality of names, forms and devotional access does not by itself prove plurality of independent ultimates, but a philosophical answer must also concede the reality of lived plural worship.

STAGE 12 GOD–WORLD–HUMAN RELATIONS — FIVE GRAMMARS THAT MUST NEVER BE EXCHANGED

CREATOR / CREATURE · SUBSTANCE / MODE · BRAHMAN / APPEARANCE · SELF / BODY · GOVERNOR / ATOMS · PHYSICAL MANIFESTATION ≠ ULTIMATE CAUSE

CONSTANT COMPARATIVE AXIS

SYSTEM	GOD / ULTIMATE	WORLD RELATION	HUMAN RELATION
Classical theism	Personal necessary creator.	Created, distinct, continuously sustained.	Creature, moral agent, object of providence.
Spinoza	One infinite substance.	Finite modes under attributes.	Finite mode; freedom through adequate understanding.
Advaita	Nirguna Brahman; empirical Īśvara.	Dependent appearance through *vivarta*.	Ātman is Brahman; empirical agency is sublated.
Rāmānuja	Personal qualified Brahman.	Real divine body; material and efficient causation.	Distinct, dependent, inseparable jīva in devotion.
Nyāya	Omniscient special self.	Efficient arrangement of eternal atoms.	Real self, karma bearer, morally governed.

PHYSICAL-MANIFESTATION CLAIM

- Observed makers have bodies.
- Therefore any ultimate cause must be physically embodied.
- Confuses intra-worldly production with metaphysical dependence.

REJECT THE INVALID ANALOGY →

PHILOSOPHICAL CORRECTION

- Effects can disclose a non-physical cause without making it a finite object.
- Efficient, sustaining and formal/metaphysical causation do not require bodily contact.
- Incarnation, manifestation, embodiment and material causation are distinct claims.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The God-world relation is not one relation under many names: identity, dependent appearance, metaphysical embodiment and efficient causation make incompatible claims about difference and dependence.

STAGE 13 HIGH-VALUE CRITICISMS AND REPLIES — STEELMAN BEFORE VERDICT

ANTHROPOMORPHISM · RELIGIOUS REMOTENESS · MODAL COLLAPSE · MĀYĀ LOCUS · EVIL IN GOD'S BODY · NYĀYA REDUNDANCY

DIALECTICAL BANK

TARGET	OBJECTION	BEST REPLY	RESIDUAL PRESSURE
Personal theism	Projects finite psychology onto infinity.	Analogy affirms perfect agency while denying creaturely limitation.	Can a person be timeless and immutable?
Impersonal ultimacy	Cannot ground prayer, grace or moral address.	Religious practice may be pedagogic or transformative rather than reciprocal.	Personal devotion becomes provisional or symbolic.
Spinoza	God collapses into matter and freedom disappears.	Nature is infinite intelligible substance; freedom is self-determination.	No providential choice or alternatives.
Advaita	Nirguṇa is empty; māyā merely names the problem.	Negation removes limits; sublation diagnoses appearance without a second reality.	Locus and positive intelligibility remain.
Rāmānuja	Worldly defect infects God's body.	Defect belongs to controlled body, not controller's essence.	Complete governance preserves responsibility.
Nyāya	Karma and atoms make God redundant.	Unconscious entities cannot intelligently coordinate order.	Why require an infinite personal governor?

EXAM METHOD → Never answer a criticism with a slogan. Identify the exact premise challenged, state the strongest available repair and show what explanatory or religious cost remains.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A graded verdict is stronger than reconciliation by assertion: a model may be logically coherent yet religiously thin, devotionally powerful yet metaphysically costly, or explanatory while revising ordinary freedom.

STAGE 14 PYQ ROUTING + MARK-SCALED ANSWER ARCHITECTURE — 13 VERIFIED OWNER QUESTIONS

2018–2024: 13 OWNER PYQS · 2025: NONE · 10m = DISTINCTION + ONE CRITIQUE · 15m = DOCTRINE + RIVAL + EVALUATION · 20m = FULL SYSTEM + TWO OBJECTIONS · NO OPTIONAL PRELIMS PYQS

- **2018** Hinduism poly-theistic? — 10m
- **2019** Personal/impersonal — 15m; man-God relation — 15m
- **2020** Freedom/omnipotence — 10m; Viśiṣṭādvaita — 20m
- **2021** Nyāya God — 10m
- **2022** Spinoza — 10m; Rāmānuja — 15m; Advaita/theism — 15m
- **2023** Personal/impersonal — 10m; immanent/transcendent — 15m
- **2024** Spinoza metaphysics — 15m; physical manifestation — 15m
- **2025** No primary Notions-of-God owner question

MARK AND DIRECTIVE DECODER

MARKS	DIRECTIVE	ARCHITECTURE	EXAMINER PENALTY
10	Elucidate / discuss	Definition → named Western/Indian example → distinction → objection/reply → explicit verdict.	Overlong survey; no direct answer.
15	State and evaluate / critically discuss	Thesis → doctrine and relation → nearest rival → objection/reply → graded conclusion.	Narration without evaluation.
20	Discuss with special reference	Classify → full system → attributes → world/person → causation/soteriology → two criticisms → verdict.	Ignoring 'special reference' or parity.

DIRECTIVE FIDELITY

- **Elucidate:** clarify a distinction.
- **Discuss:** balanced exposition plus position.
- **Evaluate / critically examine:** reconstruct, test and grade.
- **Give reasons:** criterion and defended conclusion, not a vote.

FINAL AUDIT

- Exact God-world-human grammar?
- Named evidence and technical terms translated?
- Objection, reply and residual pressure?
- No Spinoza/Advaita/Rāmānuja/Nyāya conflation?
- Conclusion answers the exact stem?

WORKBOOK STATUS

- All 13 PYQs carry full model answers.
- Objective questions are original UPSC-style practice, never labelled PYQs.
- Hard and remedial keys are non-patterned and verified against options.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A Philosophy Optional answer scores by moving from exact definition through named doctrine and argument to a qualified verdict; decorative terminology without relational analysis is penalised.

EXTRA OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT — NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

DIVINE SIMPLICITY DEBATES · MOLINISM / OCKHAMISM · OPEN THEISM · APOPHATIC COMPARISONS · ABRAHAMIC REFERENCE · PROCESS / PANENTHEIST DEPTH

ATTRIBUTE DEPTH

- Divine simplicity: modal collapse, Plantinga's property-identity objection and truthmaker replies.
- Timelessness: Boethian *nunc stans*; relation between one eternal act and temporal effects.
- Impassibility reinterpreted as constancy rather than emotional inertness.

FREEDOM SOLUTIONS

- Ockhamism: divine past belief as a soft fact.
- Molinism: middle knowledge and the grounding objection.
- Open theism: future free acts are not yet truths; classical omniscience is revised.

COMPARATIVE DEPTH

- Aquinas, Maimonides and apophatic control; Trinitarian simplicity as a bounded reference.
- Process/panentheist models trade classical immutability for relational responsiveness.
- Use only after the core doctrine named by the question is complete.

LIVE ANCHOR → The Vatican Dicastery for Interreligious Dialogue conference in Rome, 23–24 June 2026, brought Christians and Dharmic traditions together for dialogue and cooperation. It illustrates contemporary encounter among different God-concepts; it does not validate any metaphysical doctrine.

Source control: canonical Notions-of-God owner + verified 2018–2025 Philosophy of Religion PYQ ledger + regenerated uncompressed learning session. Current anchor: official Vatican communiqué, 24 June 2026; dialogue use only. Approval remains FALSE.